# Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2026)

## I. Governance and Stewardship

USA Pickleball continues its role as the National Governing Body (NGB) for the sport in the United States [cite: 1]. The 2026 Official Rulebook reflects the ongoing evolution of the sport, focusing on maintaining its traditional character while accommodating professional-level advancements [cite: 1]. The USA Pickleball Rules Committee is tasked with formulating and interpreting rules to ensure the sport's growth remains consistent across all levels of play [cite: 1].

## II. Court and Equipment Standards

The court dimensions remain a standard 20 feet by 44 feet ($6.10m \times 13.41m$) for both singles and doubles play [cite: 1]. The net height is specified at 36 inches at the sidelines and 34 inches at the center [cite: 1]. The 2026 standards include updated protocols for equipment testing, specifically regarding paddle deflection and surface texture to ensure fair competition [cite: 1]. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) continues to be defined as the 7-foot area on both sides of the net where volleying is prohibited [cite: 1].

## III. Service Mechanics: Clarity and Precision

### The Volley Serve

The volley serve must be hit underhand, with contact occurring below the waist [cite: 1]. The arm must move in an upward arc, and the highest point of the paddle head must be below the wrist [cite: 1]. The ball must be visible to the receiver and the official during the release [cite: 1].

### The Drop Serve

The drop serve remains a legal alternative [cite: 1]. The ball must be released from a stationary hand or dropped without any added force, spin, or manipulation [cite: 1]. If the ball is thrown or pushed downward during the release, it is a fault [cite: 1].

## IV. Gameplay Dynamics and Momentum

The Two-Bounce Rule is fundamental: each side must play the ball off the bounce once before volleys are permitted [cite: 1]. The 2026 rules reinforce that momentum faults in the NVZ are strictly interpreted; touching the zone after a volley is a fault even if the ball is dead

[cite: 1]. Side-out scoring remains the primary method for sanctioned play, ensuring that points are earned only by the serving team [cite: 1].

## V. Integrity and Player Conduct

The 2026 rulebook places high importance on sportsmanship and the 'Code of Conduct' [cite: 1]. Players are expected to make their own line calls and report faults with honesty [cite: 1]. New for 2026 are enhanced guidelines for technical warnings and fouls related to unsportsmanlike behavior, paddle abuse, and verbal disruptions [cite: 1].